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How to Generate Sales Leads Online



By **Chaz Wilke**, Staff Writer

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You may have heard that affiliate marketers have the potential to make large sums of money by generating sales leads online. In fact, Forrester Consulting predicts that the affiliate marketing industry will grow to over [\\$4 billion by 2016](#).

But you might be a little confused about the sales lead generation process. Let's go over a few of the basic elements of generating sales leads.

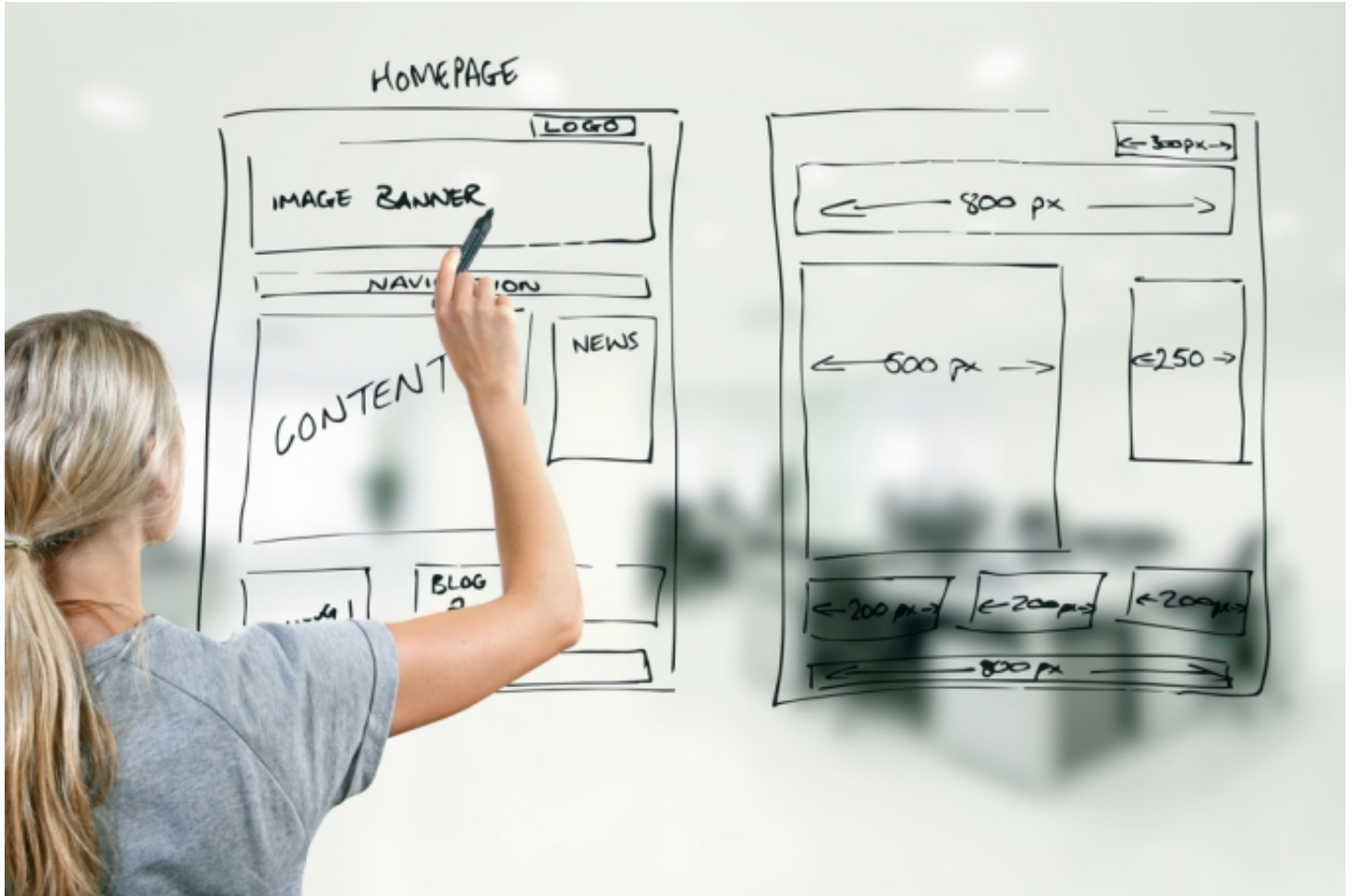
Website

You need a site that you can direct prospective leads to visit. This could be a site you've designed, or a template site an affiliate network provides. Once you have somewhere to drive traffic, you must look at which type of visitor you want to attract. This essentially means choosing your content's subject matter and the product or service you hope to promote.

Building a website is now easier than ever. Previously, you would have needed to learn HTML and hand code a site with a text editor. Now free platforms such as WordPress have automated much of the heavy lifting required in getting a site up and running.

Even while the majority of a site's construction can be automated by a Content Management System (CMS) such as WordPress, you must still select your layout template and color scheme. Presenting an appealing

color scheme helps visitor trust in you and what you are promoting. Generating sales leads requires that potential leads will trust the legitimacy of you and your site. If a prospective lead feels wary when handing over personal information on your site, you are unlikely to generate sales leads in large quantities.



Blog Content

Blog content will become your bread and butter; your secret sauce, if you will. Your blog content can be a magnet that attracts traffic in droves. This is why it is so important to choose a service or product that you have interest in. Since you not only need to sound like an expert in your niche, you also need to show your passion for what you are selling.

"A good blog will create a [sense of community](#). When there's a sense of community, it's much easier to target worthwhile customers," says Jeff Mason, vice president of marketing at Velaro.

If your chosen product or service matches your interests, and you create compelling content, then you have the best chance at finding and maintaining an audience. This content will be the backbone of your site, the reason people come and stay on your site, and the main persuasion for your visitors to convert into sales leads.

While effective content attracts new visitors, you may still need to promote the content you create to generate

widespread interest.

Promotion

Without content promotion, your passionate and compelling content will sit undiscovered. Once visitors begin frequenting your site, you must engage your audience. "You want to [encourage people to engage](#) with the content, comment on it, and share," says Matthew Gratt of Convince & Convert digital marketing advisors.

There are numerous ways you can promote your content as well as your personal brand:

PPC

Pay per click (PPC) advertising is a popular method to drive traffic to almost any website. Since you are only paying for the advertisement when people click to be taken to your site, you can be confident your money is being spent to attract eyeballs to your site. If you target less expensive long-tail keywords, you may find a nice stream of new traffic to your site without breaking the bank.



Guest Blogging

Guest bloggers usually write posts on sites similar to their own. For the site owner, it's an easy way to get fresh, compelling content. Each site has different requirements for submitting a guest post, so ask the site owner what he or she hopes to see from you before committing to writing the content. Usually, you will get to link back to your site, but if not, your name and brand will still be visible on another site and to all of its traffic.

Reach Out to Influencers

Call out influencers in your content and then let them know via email or Twitter. This may result in the influencer tweeting out your content on their official Twitter account. Depending on the reach of the influencer, this may provide you a huge uptick in traffic.

Social Media

You should always blast Twitter and Facebook when you publish fresh content. LinkedIn is another great social network, but some content may not fit the business-centered focus of that site.

Email Marketing

You probably have an email capture form on your site. If you publish great content, then there is a good chance that people would love to be updated when you release something fresh. With an email list, you have a readymade audience just waiting to come back to your site and check out what you've published.



Conversion

If you don't convert your visitors into leads then this whole process will be unprofitable. Converting visitors into leads is the final process in generating sales leads. Once you have people on your site and reading your content, you need to find simple and intuitive ways to push your visitor to convert into a sales lead. This is how you get paid.

At minimum, persuade your visitors to give you their contact information. This may not seem immediately profitable but as Brandon Choquette at ImageWorks LLC says, "Once you have contact information from website visitors who are interested in your product or service you can [begin nurturing these leads](#) with valuable information to stay top of mind until they are sales ready."

You might use a form on your landing page, or perhaps at the end of your content or on the sidebar alongside what you've written. How you choose to work visitor conversion into your sales lead generation method is up to you or your affiliate network. Your patience and persistence with visitor conversion will define your ultimate success.

Takeaway

If you've read this far, that means you're not only interested in generating sales leads but also now have a handle on exactly what to do. The sales lead generation process isn't quick. It may take some time to build large amounts of traffic on your site. If you focus on quality and compelling content, in time your traffic should grow. Then it is only a matter of converting those who visit into sales leads.

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Hailing from Chicago and a product of the Illinois public school system, Chaz Wilke is a professional writer who has written for newspaper, TV, radio, video games, blogs, and film. In his spare time, Chaz enjoys hiking and discovering the hidden gems and oddities of Los Angeles. He also juggles.

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